Everyday Chinese Idioms

36 chengyu 成語 for real conversation

Traditional characters • BoPoMoFo 注音 • Pinyin • English meaning • example sentence

Print it, stick it on your wall, and learn one idiom a day. Every idiom is shown the PandaSpeak way: Traditional characters with both BoPoMoFo (Zhuyin) and Pinyin, a plain-English meaning, and a natural example sentence.

Body-Part Idioms 身體部位

手忙腳亂

ㄕㄡˇ ㄇㄤˊ ㄐㄧㄠˇ ㄌㄨㄢˋ

shǒu máng jiǎo luàn

to be in a rush and confused, implies being disorganized or panicking

他第一次做飯，弄得手忙腳亂。

Tā dì yī cì zuòfàn, nòng de shǒu máng jiǎo luàn. — It was his first time cooking, and he made a mess in a panic.

目瞪口呆

ㄇㄨˋ ㄉㄥˋ ㄎㄡˇ ㄉㄞ

mù dèng kǒu dāi

eyes staring and mouth frozen, implies being stunned or speechless with shock

看到那個結果，大家都目瞪口呆。

Kàn dào nàge jiéguǒ, dàjiā dōu mù dèng kǒu dāi. — Seeing that result, everyone was stunned speechless.

口是心非

ㄎㄡˇ ㄕˋ ㄒㄧㄣ ㄈㄟ

kǒu shì xīn fēi

mouth says yes but heart says no, implies being hypocritical or saying one thing but meaning another

他口是心非，你別相信他。

Tā kǒu shì xīn fēi, nǐ bié xiāngxìn tā. — He says one thing but means another, so don't believe him.

心口如一

ㄒㄧㄣ ㄎㄡˇ ㄖㄨˊ ㄧ

xīn kǒu rú yī

heart and mouth as one, implies being honest and speaking truthfully from the heart

她是心口如一的人，從不說謊。

Tā shì xīn kǒu rú yī de rén, cóng bù shuōhuǎng. — She is an honest person who speaks from the heart and never lies.

頭頭是道

ㄊㄡˊ ㄊㄡˊ ㄕˋ ㄉㄠˋ

tóu tóu shì dào

speaking in an organized and logical way, implies explaining something clearly and convincingly

他分析得頭頭是道。

Tā fēnxī de tóu tóu shì dào. — He analyzed it clearly and logically.

頭暈目眩

ㄊㄡˊ ㄩㄣ ㄇㄨˋ ㄒㄩㄢˋ

tóu yūn mù xuàn

head spinning and eyes dizzy, implies feeling overwhelmed or physically unwell

天氣太熱，我頭暈目眩。

Tiānqì tài rè, wǒ tóu yūn mù xuàn. — The weather is too hot, and I feel dizzy and overwhelmed.

耳濡目染

ㄦˇ ㄖㄨˊ ㄇㄨˋ ㄖㄢˇ

ěr rú mù rǎn

ears soaked and eyes dyed, implies being unconsciously influenced by long-term exposure

他從小耳濡目染，也愛上了音樂。

Tā cóngxiǎo ěr rú mù rǎn, yě ài shàng le yīnyuè. — Influenced since childhood by what he saw and heard, he also fell in love with music.

耳目一新

ㄦˇ ㄇㄨˋ ㄧ ㄒㄧㄣ

ěr mù yī xīn

ears and eyes refreshed, implies experiencing something impressively new and refreshing

這家餐廳的設計讓人耳目一新。

Zhè jiā cāntīng de shèjì ràng rén ěr mù yī xīn. — The design of this restaurant is refreshing and new.

眼高手低

ㄧㄢˇ ㄍㄠ ㄕㄡˇ ㄉ

yǎn gāo shǒu dī

eyes high but hands low, implies having high ambitions but lacking real ability

他眼高手低，什麼都做不好。

Tā yǎn gāo shǒu dī, shénme dōu zuò bù hǎo. — He aims high but lacks skill, so he can't do anything well.

眉開眼笑

ㄇㄟˊ ㄎㄞ ㄧㄢˇ ㄒㄧㄠˋ

méi kāi yǎn xiào

eyebrows open and eyes smiling, implies being extremely happy and delighted

聽到好消息，她眉開眼笑。

Tīng dào hǎo xiāoxi, tā méi kāi yǎn xiào. — Hearing the good news, she was beaming with joy.

手到擒來

ㄕㄡˇ ㄉㄠˋ ㄑㄧㄣˊ ㄌㄞˊ

shǒu dào qín lái

reach out and capture, implies something very easy to accomplish

這件事對他來說手到擒來。

Zhè jiàn shì duì tā lái shuō shǒu dào qín lái. — This matter is very easy for him to accomplish.

手足無措

ㄕㄡˇ ㄗㄨˊ ㄨˊ ㄘㄨㄛˋ

shǒu zú wú cuò

hands and feet have no place, implies being at a loss and not knowing what to do

遇到突發狀況，他手足無措。

Yù dào tūfā zhuàngkuàng, tā shǒu zú wú cuò. — When faced with an emergency, he was at a loss.

肺腑之言

ㄈㄟˋ ㄈㄨˇ ㄓ ㄧㄢˊ

fèi fǔ zhī yán

words from the lungs and organs, implies sincere words from the bottom of one's heart

這是我的肺腑之言，請你相信我。

Zhè shì wǒ de fèi fǔ zhī yán, qǐng nǐ xiāngxìn wǒ. — These are my heartfelt words, please believe me.

肝膽相照

ㄍㄢ ㄉㄢˇ ㄒㄧㄤ ㄓㄠˋ

gān dǎn xiāng zhào

liver and gallbladder illuminating each other, implies being true and loyal friends who trust each other completely

他們是肝膽相照的好朋友。

Tāmen shì gān dǎn xiāng zhào de hǎo péngyǒu. — They are loyal friends who trust each other completely.

骨瘦如柴

ㄍㄨˇ ㄕㄡˋ ㄖㄨˊ ㄔㄞˊ

gǔ shòu rú chái

bones thin as firewood, implies being extremely skinny or emaciated

他生病後骨瘦如柴。

Tā shēngbìng hòu gǔ shòu rú chái. — After getting sick, he became extremely skinny.

粉身碎骨

ㄈㄣˇ ㄕㄣ ㄙㄨㄟˋ ㄍㄨˇ

fěn shēn suì gǔ

body powdered and bones shattered, implies being willing to sacrifice everything or facing total destruction

為了家人，他粉身碎骨也在所不惜。

Wèi le jiārén, tā fěn shēn suì gǔ yě zài suǒ bù xī. — For his family, he would sacrifice everything without hesitation.

血口噴人

ㄒㄩㄝˋ ㄎㄡˇ ㄆㄣ ㄖㄣˊ

xuè kǒu pēn rén

spitting blood from the mouth at someone, implies making vicious false accusations against someone

你別血口噴人，我根本沒做。

Nǐ bié xuè kǒu pēn rén, wǒ gēnběn méi zuò. — Don't make vicious false accusations, I didn't do it at all.

胸有成竹

ㄒㄩㄥ ㄧㄡˇ ㄔㄥˊ ㄓㄨˊ

xiōng yǒu chéng zhú

chest has mature bamboo, implies having a well-thought-out plan and being confident

面對考試，他胸有成竹。

Miàn duì kǎoshì, tā xiōng yǒu chéng zhú. — Facing the exam, he was fully confident and well prepared.

Nature Idioms 大自然

一石二鳥

ㄧ ㄕˊ ㄦˋ ㄋㄧㄠˇ

yī shí èr niǎo

To kill two birds with one stone; to achieve two goals with a single action.

我想去買東西，也想看朋友，去台北可以一石二鳥。

wǒ xiǎng qù mǎi dōng xī，yě xiǎng kàn péng yǒu，qù tái běi kě yǐ yī shí èr niǎo。 — I want to go shopping and also want to see a friend, going to Taipei can kill two birds with one stone.

雨過天晴

ㄩˇ ㄍㄨㄛˋ ㄊㄧㄢ ㄑㄧㄥˊ

yǔ guò tiān qíng

The rain passes and the sky clears; troubles pass and things return to normal or better.

雨過天晴，我們可以出去玩了。

yǔ guò tiān qíng，wǒ men kě yǐ chū qù wán le。 — The rain has passed and the sky cleared, we can go out and play now.

山明水秀

ㄕㄢ ㄇㄧㄥˊ ㄕㄨㄟˇ

Bright mountains and elegant waters; describing beautiful natural scenery.

這個地方山明水秀，我很喜歡。

ㄒㄧㄡˋ
shān míng shuǐ xiù

zhè ge dì fāng shān míng shuǐ xiù，wǒ hěn xǐ huān。 — This place has beautiful scenery, I really like it.

鳥語花香

ㄋㄧㄠˇ ㄩˇ ㄏㄨㄚ ˉ ㄒㄧㄤ ˉ
niǎo yǔ huā xiāng

Birds sing and flowers give forth fragrance; describing a beautiful spring scene.

春天來了，公園裡鳥語花香。
chūn tiān lái le，gōng yuán lǐ niǎo yǔ huā xiāng。 — Spring has come, the park is full of singing birds and fragrant flowers.

風平浪靜

ㄈㄥ ˉ ㄆㄧㄥˊ ㄌㄤˋ ㄐㄧㄥˋ
fēng píng làng jìng

The wind is calm and the waves are still; describing a peaceful situation or calm waters.

今天海上風平浪靜，我們可以去釣魚。
jīn tiān hǎi shàng fēng píng làng jìng，wǒ men kě yǐ qù diào yú。 — Today the sea is calm, we can go fishing.

水到渠成

ㄕㄨㄟˇ ㄉㄠˋ ㄑㄩˊ ㄔㄥˊ
shuǐ dào qú chéng

When water arrives a channel is formed; meaning things succeed naturally when conditions are ripe.

你努力學習，成功就會水到渠成。
nǐ nǔ lì xué xí，chéng gōng jiù huì shuǐ dào qú chéng。 — If you study hard, success will come naturally when conditions are right.

春暖花開

ㄔㄨㄣ ˉ ㄋㄨㄢˇ ㄏㄨㄚ ˉ ㄎㄞ ˉ
chūn nuǎn huā kāi

Spring is warm and flowers bloom; describing a pleasant spring scene or a good turn of events.

春暖花開，我們去看花吧。
chūn nuǎn huā kāi，wǒ men qù kàn huā ba。 — Spring is warm and flowers are blooming, let us go see the flowers.

秋高氣爽

ㄑㄧㄡ ˉ ㄍㄠ ˉ ㄑㄧˋ ㄕㄨㄤˇ
qiū gāo qì shuǎng

Autumn is high and the air is crisp; describing clear and pleasant autumn weather.

秋高氣爽，我想去爬山。
qiū gāo qì shuǎng，wǒ xiǎng qù pá shān。 — The autumn air is crisp, I want to go hiking.

雪中送炭

ㄒㄩㄝˇ ㄓㄨㄥ ˉ ㄙㄨㄥˋ ㄊㄢˋ
xuě zhōng sòng tàn

To send charcoal in the snow; meaning to provide help when someone is in urgent need.

他在我最難的時候幫我，真是雪中送炭。
tā zài wǒ zuì nán de shí hòu bāng wǒ，zhēn shì xuě zhōng sòng tàn。 — He helped me when I was in the most difficulty, truly sending charcoal in the snow.

海闊天空

ㄏㄞˇ ㄎㄨㄛˋ ㄊㄧㄢ ˉ ㄎㄨㄥ ˉ
hǎi kuò tiān kōng

The sea is broad and the sky is vast; describing openness, freedom, or boundless imagination.

我們一起聊天，海闊天空，很開心。
wǒ men yī qǐ liáo tiān，hǎi kuò tiān kōng，hěn kāi xīn。 — We chatted together freely and happily.

Friendship Idioms 友誼

一見如故

ㄧ ㄐㄧㄢˋ ㄖㄨˊ ㄍㄨˋ

yī jiàn rú gù

To feel like old friends at first meeting; implying instant chemistry and deep connection with someone new.

我和他一見如故，聊得很開心。

wǒ hé tā yī jiàn rú gù，liáo de hěn kāi xīn。 — He and I felt like old friends at first meeting, we chatted very happily.

情同手足

ㄑㄧㄥˊ ㄊㄨㄥˊ ㄕㄡˇ ㄗㄨˊ

qíng tóng shǒu zú

Feelings like hands and feet; implying a bond as close as siblings.

我和我的好朋友情同手足。

wǒ hé wǒ de hǎo péng yǒu qíng tóng shǒu zú。 — My good friend and I are as close as siblings.

推心置腹

ㄊㄨㄟ ㄒㄧㄣ ㄓˋ ㄈㄨˋ

tuī xīn zhì fù

To place one's heart into another's belly; implying to confide in someone openly and sincerely.

他對我推心置腹，我很感動。

tā duì wǒ tuī xīn zhì fù，wǒ hěn gǎn dòng。 — He confided in me openly and sincerely, I was very touched.

風雨同舟

ㄈㄥ ㄩˇ ㄊㄨㄥˊ ㄓㄡ

fēng yǔ tóng zhōu

To share a boat in wind and rain; implying to stand together through hardships.

我們是好朋友，要風雨同舟。

wǒ men shì hǎo péng yǒu，yào fēng yǔ tóng zhōu。 — We are good friends, we must stand together through hardships.

志同道合

ㄓˋ ㄊㄨㄥˊ ㄉㄠˋ ㄏㄜˊ

zhì tóng dào hé

Same ambition and same path; implying people who share the same goals and interests.

我們志同道合，所以常常一起工作。

wǒ men zhì tóng dào hé，suǒ yǐ cháng cháng yī qǐ gōng zuò。 — We share the same goals and interests, so we often work together.

心心相印

ㄒㄧㄣ ㄒㄧㄣ ㄒㄧㄤ ㄧㄣˋ

xīn xīn xiāng yìn

Hearts mutually imprinted; implying two people understand each other deeply without words.

他和他的太太心心相印。

tā hé tā de tài tai xīn xīn xiāng yìn。 — He and his wife understand each other deeply.

患難之交

ㄏㄨㄢˋ ㄋㄢˋ ㄓ ㄐㄧㄠ

huàn nàn zhī jiāo

Friendship formed through adversity; implying a bond that is tested and proven in hard times.

他是我的患難之交，我永遠不會忘記他。

tā shì wǒ de huàn nàn zhī jiāo，wǒ yǒng yuǎn bù huì wàng jì tā。 — He is my friend tested through adversity, I will never forget him.

To treat all people equally; implying fairness and no favoritism toward anyone.

老師對每個學生都一視同仁。

一視同仁

ㄧ ˉ ㄕˋ ㄊㄨㄥˊ ㄖㄣˊ

yī shì tóng rén

lǎo shī duì měi ge xué shēng dōu yī shì tóng rén 。 — The teacher treats every student equally.

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